resent outside interference or military. Each has its own intellectual framework for exclusion of outside powers, the Monroe doctrine in case of the United States and the Indira doctrine for India. Both have a deep national identity and strong sense of national exceptionalism. Both also see themselves as being different from the old imperialist powers. Finally, both India and the US emphasize bilateral autonomy in relations with countries and yet are deeply involved in multilateral institutions like the United Nations.

India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, and his colleagues in the Indian independence movement sought inspiration from ancient and medieval India. Ancient philosophers taught them that the subcontinent was one civilizational and geographical entity. These philosophers also provided moral attitudes – both idealist and realist – that were adapted to proclaim that contemporary India can only grow under the shadow of its past. This general principle, of the present being guided by the past and the future only reflecting it, has applied strongly to the realm of external relations. Ancient Indian philosophers emphasized the importance of avoiding disengagement from other peoples and advised against encroaching on or taking over territory that was outside the subcontinent. India's founding elite embraced the belief that South Asia is central to India's external relations and yet India needs to be a vital player in global politics. This followed from the ancient philosophers' views, and has been a consistent pillar of India's world view since Independence.

The influence of ancient India's most famous political philosopher Chanakya lies not only in the symbolism of naming the diplomatic enclave in New Delhi after him but in the way in which India has sought a system of layered relations coupled with the mistrust of other nations – the core of Chanakya's mandala theory. Chanakya explains why, despite close relations with Western countries, India still maintains ties with Russia, old friends in